fundamental and legal rights of every citizen are protected and all citizens are fairly treated.

The IAS Provides Invaluable Policy Experience

The Indian Administrative Service (IAS) makes up a significant chunk of India's civil services. It has a special place among India's civil services for four principal reasons. First, it is a generalist service and therefore works across the widest spectrum of the government in India. Other departmentalized civil services have a much deeper role in their specific arena.

Second, it is a service common to the Centre and states whereas the central civil services serve Central government ministries/departments and most state civil services serve the respective departments at the state level.

Third, being responsible for implementing the widest spectrum of laws and development programmes and delivering most of the public goods and services, it touches the people of India most and, therefore, is most informed of the ground realities of the country.

Fourth, as it manages most of the positions of the secretaries to the government in the states and at the Centre, it participates in policymaking most closely.

This fourfold special character of the IAS makes it an integrationist of the Union of States, which India is, and qualifies it to occupy most of the broader ministries, departments and organizations, like finance, the Cabinet Secretariat, elections, district administration and disaster management.

I joined the IAS and served for thirty-five years. The service gave me an amazing opportunity to work across many sectors of the economy and participate in policy implementation and formulation over a very wide spectrum of economic activity, culminating in a two-year stint as the Secretary in charge of the Department of Economic Affairs, Government of India.